The Journal of Sexual Medicine, 2026, **23**(5), qdag093
https://doi.org/10.1093/jsxmed/qdag093
Published: April 16, 2026
Letter to the Editor

Letter to the Editor on "The impact of elective adult circumcision for religious reasons on sexual function and satisfaction: a pilot study"

Tim Hammond*

Genital Autonomy Legal Defense and Education Fund, Palm Springs, CA 92262, United States
*Corresponding author: Genital Autonomy Legal Defense and Education Fund, Palm Springs, CA 92262, United States.
Email: circharmsurvey@gmail.com

Fihman et al. (2026) examined sexual function and satisfaction following elective adult circumcision for religious reasons, contributing data where empirical research remains limited.[1] The observations noted below may help contextualize those findings.

One factor that may have influenced responses is the interaction between religious commitment and postoperative self-evaluation. In general, some individuals may experience social or internal pressures that shape how they report satisfaction or regret following elective medical procedures. This phenomenon has been described in the broader literature on decision regret across various elective surgeries. Contextualizing how religious or cultural expectations can influence post-circumcision self-report can help readers better understand the study's outcomes.

While no major postoperative complications were reported among the adult participants, the authors later reference neonatal circumcision. Adult and neonatal procedures differ significantly in terms of anatomical development and consent. Small surgical errors during infant circumcision can become magnified in adolescence and adulthood, resulting in unpredictable adverse physical and/or sexual consequences.[2] The involuntary nature of newborn circumcision has been identified by numerous researchers to be a contributor to later emotional or psychological distress.[3]

The cited 2012 American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) Circumcision Task Force statement concluded that benefits slightly outweighed risks, but the policy curiously expired in 2017 without being renewed or reaffirmed. In a November 2025 interview, two distinguished members of that AAP Circumcision Task Force essentially disavowed the validity of its findings.[4]

Andrew Freedman, MD described neonatal circumcision as a non-therapeutic procedure, remarking "If it can be called a preventative medicine, it is at the very weakest level." Douglas Diekema, MD declared "When you look at all the data, I don't think you can honestly say in a recommendation that the benefits outweigh the risks."

These comments are intended to inspire constructive dialogue and to encourage more robust medical, ethical, and legal research toward safeguarding healthy unconsenting minors from the increasingly documented harms of nontherapeutic circumcision, while protecting their fundamental human right to bodily integrity, including genital autonomy.

Funding

None declared.

Disclosure

The Genital Autonomy Legal Defense and Education Fund (GALDEF) is a nonprofit civil society organization advocating for improved pediatric practice and medical ethics policies that recognize every child's basic human right to bodily integrity, including genital autonomy.

References

1. Fihman M, Chertin B, Peretz D, *et al*. The impact of elective adult circumcision for religious reasons on sexual function and satisfaction: a pilot study. *J Sex Med*. 2026;**23**(2):1–2.
2. Hammond T, Carmack A. Long-term adverse outcomes from neonatal circumcision reported in a survey of 1,008 men: an overview of health and human rights implications. *Int J Hum Rights*. 2017;**21**(2):189–218. https://doi.org/10.1080/13642987.2016.1260007
3. Uberoi M, Abdulcadir J, Ohl DA, *et al*. Potentially underrecognized late-stage physical and psychosexual complications of non-therapeutic neonatal penile circumcision: a qualitative and quantitative analysis of self reports from an online community forum. *Int J Impot Res*. 2022;**35**(3):1–8. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41443-022-00619-8
4. Buckler M. As controversies mount, circumcision policies need a rethink. *J Med Ethics*. Published online November 13, 2025;**0**:1–5 [Epub ahead of print]. https://doi.org/10.1136/jme-2025-111357

Received: February 16, 2026. **Accepted:** February 22, 2026.
© The Author(s) 2026. Published by Oxford University Press on behalf of The International Society for Sexual Medicine. All rights reserved. For commercial re-use, please contact reprints@oup.com for reprints and translation rights for reprints. All other permissions can be obtained through our RightsLink service via the Permissions link on the article page on our site—for further information please contact journals.permissions@oup.com.

Downloaded from https://academic.oup.com/jsm/article/23/5/qdag093/8655693 by guest on 17 April 2026